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Remembering the Holocaust: A Lesson to All of Humankind

To the new generation rising from the twenty-first century, the Holocaust may feel like nothing more than just a distant, painful memory. Many of us are lucky enough to have never experienced anything as horrifying as the many atrocities committed during this time. Still, it's important to remember that the society and background from which the Holocaust emerged wasn't as distant from ourselves as we think. The Holocaust was not only a campaign led by Nazi authorities— it was also a result of the actions and inactions of everyday people as they witnessed the inhumane actions of those in charge.

Many targeted individuals spoke out against the injustice. Altogether, 1.5 million Jews retaliated by fighting with the Allies or in secret partisan organizations. After learning that the so-called “camps” were actually graveyards, many Jews revolted as a last act of resistance. Out of the many uprisings that happened, the most prominent example would be the Warsaw Ghetto Uprising of 1943. A 23-year-old Jew named Mordecai Anielewicz formed the ZOB, or Jewish Fighting Organization, after learning of the killing center they would be sent to. Throughout 1943, the ZOB resisted German authorities by firing on German troops during a round-up of ghetto residents to a killing center. The Warsaw Ghetto Uprising lasted for one month, with

7,000 Jews dying while fighting or hiding. Targeted individuals started out as ordinary people who ended up fighting to their last breath with the honor of a warrior.

In addition to the directly targeted Jews, a few individuals resisted as well. Made up of German citizens, the White Rose Movement distributed anti-Nazi papers to combat Nazi propaganda. Protestant residents in the southern French village of Le Chambon-sur-Lignon hid thousands of Jews, many of them children, in homes, convents, and monasteries. French clergymen sheltered 12,000 Jewish children then smuggled them into neutral Switzerland and Spain. Even Warsaw Zoo director Jan Zabinski saved many Polish Jews by hiding them in the zoo. These individuals were motivated by personal morals or religious conviction. Still, they were taking an incredible risk—many helpers were put into concentration camps as prisoners, arrested, or immediately executed due to treason. Meanwhile, the majority of people who chose to stay silent and do nothing were silenced by fear. Staying silent never helps the victim; it only makes it easier for the perpetrator.

The choices of nations on whether to act or not to act also deeply impacted the outcome of the Holocaust. From early on, British and American intelligence knew of genocide in German-occupied eastern Europe through intercepted German radio. Despite this, the efforts made by the Allies to further stop the Holocaust were disappointing. By 1938, a quarter of the Jewish population in Germany had fled the country. Such a large influx of Jewish immigrants were unwelcome in many countries, including the United States. In a 1938 survey of Americans, 69% disapproved of accepting German Jewish refugees. This shows that antisemitism was not limited to Nazi Germany.

In the summer of 1938, representatives from 32 nations met at the nine-day Evian Conference to discuss Jewish immigration. Out of them, the Dominican Republic was the only

country that agreed to welcome more refugees. The German government scoffed that it was ironic how other nations denounced the German treatment of Jews, yet were unwilling to do anything about it themselves when given an opportunity.

On the other hand, Denmark was the only German-occupied country to actively resist its Jewish citizens from being deported. The government organized a nationwide effort to smuggle its Jewish population of 8,000 to neutral Sweden. Everyday citizens helped hide Jews in homes, hospitals, and churches. Fishermen helped transport 7,200 Danish Jews and 680 non-Jewish family members to neutral Sweden.

The outcome of the Holocaust was shaped by the choices of bystanders of whether or not to take action. Some were everyday-citizen-turned-prisoners who bravely fought for justice to their very last breath. Some were observers-turned-allies who selflessly risked their own lives in the name of what they believed was right. The decision of one individual may seem insignificant, but in reality, every generous deed, no matter how small, contributes to one less person being harmed. The Holocaust is a lesson for not just the victims and perpetrators, but for all of humankind: inaction and action all have consequences, so choose wisely for a better future.

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